

Quiet resilience: Among the mid-table sides, Punjab FC has refused to go down easily, losing narrowly to Jamshedpur and Mohun Bagan but remaining unbeaten in the other games in the ISL this season.

Pics: AIFF MEDIA

head coach initially, with six losses in his first seven games in charge.

The tide began turning with a 2-2 draw against Mumbai City, followed by a 1-1 draw with Jamshedpur FC. Then his side beat three-time ISL finalist Kerala Blasters, a team Tchórz had taken care of as assistant coach last season.

The club has since risen to around mid-table. "We are at the start of building something completely new here in Delhi, and for us, the focus is on creating a strong foundation — through hard work, clear identity, and consistent performances," Tchórz said.

For Blasters, on the other hand, winds of change arrived quite late as it changed its coach from David Catala to Ashley Westwood — a move that saw the team get its first win past the halfway mark of the league.

A tale of contrasts

For promoted I-League sides, it has been a tale of contrasts so far. While Punjab FC and Inter Kashi have placed themselves well as mid-table sides, Punjab has refused to go down easily, losing narrowly to Jamshedpur and Bagan but remaining unbeaten in the other games in the ISL this season [at the time of writing].

Meanwhile, Kashi, which started strongly with three unbeaten matches, suffered a slump before bouncing back with consecutive victories.

On the other hand, Mohammedan Sporting, which reached the Durand Cup final four years ago and won the I-League in 2024, has sunk into the quicksand of crisis both on and off



the field.

Starting the season with an all-Indian side under former India defender Mehrajuddin Wadoo, the gulf in quality, despite its fighting spirit, has weighed too heavily on it. The result has been losses in seven matches in as many rounds, leaving it in a precarious position in the relegation battle.

"I feel the effort the players have put in deserves more points, but our focus remains unchanged," Wadoo said. "Our primary objective has been survival. We still have six matches left, and we will give everything to achieve that."

Mohammedan Sporting's potential relegation — which would be the first in the ISL — would open the door for another Indian Football League (IFL). The IFL, rebranded from the I-League, has Kibu Vicuna's (right) Diamond Harbour leading the regular season.

Vicuna, who guided Bagan to the I-League title in 2020 as coach, has inspired Diamond Harbour to an almost Wrexham-like run of consecutive promotions and will try to complete the arc with yet another

title and a spot in the Indian men's top flight.

As the business ends of both leagues arrive, the good news is that the uncertainty has followed a full, though truncated, season. But the question lingers: which teams will have the last laugh across both divisions of Indian men's football?



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